

Overamping: Stimulant Overdose



NEXT Distro
STAY ALIVE, STAY SAFE.

Have you ever felt too uncomfortable or weird (not in a nice way) after taking stims or uppers like crack, cocaine, or meth? You could have been overamping. Overamping is specific to “overdosing” on stimulants. Using the word “overamping” helps us differentiate from an opioid overdose. Overamps differ in how they happen, what they look like, and how to respond.

When people talk about overdose, they are usually talking about respiratory depression, which is slowed or shallow breathing. Respiratory depression is usually caused by opioids, or any combination of mixing benzos, alcohol and opioids (“downers”), and is extremely dangerous. These kinds of overdoses can often be reversed with naloxone. Overamping is different because while it can be a really uncomfortable experience, it isn’t usually life-threatening. There’s no medical antidote like naloxone, but there are ways that you can manage your experience and keep yourself safe.

What causes overamping?

- Taking a higher dose than you’re used to, maybe because you aren’t sure of the strength or purity of your substance of choice
- Having a lowered tolerance after a period of not using, such as after being incarcerated, detoxing, or simply taking a break
- A lack of sleep, especially after multiple days of little to no rest
- Using in an unfamiliar environment or with unfamiliar people
- Using a different route of administration than you are accustomed to
- Feeling sick, which makes your body respond to drugs in different ways

What are physical and mental signs of overamping?

Mental Symptoms

- Confusion
- Restlessness
- Hypervigilance
- Intense panic
- Hallucinations/delusions
- Extreme paranoia
- Extreme agitation
- Increased aggressiveness
- Suicidal ideation

Physical Symptoms

- Jerking movements
- An inability to stay still
- Chest pain
- Irregular breathing
- High body temperature
- Passing out (but still breathing)
- Uncontrollable teeth grinding
- Racing heartbeats

You know your body and your baseline best.

What might look uncomfortable to some might feel normal — or even good! — to you! If you do start to feel too uncomfortable, noticing and naming what is going on is an important first step to managing your experience.

How can I prevent overamping?

Get enough sleep and take breaks!

Sleep is the best medicine. Lack of sleep increases the chance of overamping because even without drugs, little to no sleep can severely impact you mentally and physically.

Stay hydrated and feed yourself.

Drinking plenty of fluids and eating nutrient-dense meals can help your body feel better overall.



Start low and slow.

Starting with a smaller dose when you get a new bag can help you safely gauge what feels like the right amount for you. Same goes for if you’re using somewhere new or with new people — reducing your dose and taking it slow can make it easier to check in with yourself about how you feel.



Pay attention to your dose.

If you have a scale, weighing out your stuff can help you notice if there’s a dose that consistently makes you feel uncomfortable and what dose feels just right. Remember, the drug supply is often unreliable and potency can change from batch to batch, seller to seller, and city to city. What looks like the same dose can feel different **depending on where it came from and how you take it.**

Take care of your body, however you can.

This could look like taking a shower, taking a walk, or eating fruits and veggies.

What do I do when someone is overamping and it is not an emergency?

Most of the time overamping is not a medical emergency. Anxiety and mental discomfort are common while overamping, but you don’t have to sit through your discomfort. Try different strategies for calming and see what works for you — some of these techniques will work better at different

times. While these steps won't always take away these uncomfortable feelings, they can help manage the discomfort as the drug wears off with time.

These strategies can also be used when you are experiencing anxiety in your daily life when you are not high — they're great self-care tips for everyday feelings too!

Cool yourself down.

Place ice packs or a cool, wet towel under your armpits and knees, crack a window, or sit in front of a fan or in the shade.

Hydrate and nourish yourself.

Drink some water or a sports drink like Gatorade and eat a nutrient-dense snack. Avoid drinks with caffeine, which can increase the intensity of your experience. If you can't find Gatorade, a salty snack or a small amount of salt mixed into your water will help your body systems stay balanced and replenish nutrients.

Rest.

Take a nap, close your eyes, or lay or sit down somewhere comfy. You can practice breathing or meditation exercises, or listen to some calming music.

Shower.

A cool or warm shower can help bring mental and physical relief.

Change up your environment.

Take a walk, get some fresh air, or move to a more comfortable place.

Physical contact.

Massaging yourself, or asking someone else to massage you can help ground you in your body.

Talk to yourself or someone else about what is happening.

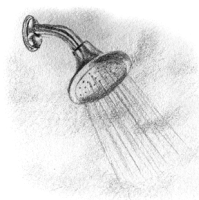
It can be very powerful to name your feelings and remind yourself that what you are experiencing is temporary.

Avoid using more, different substances, including alcohol.

It can be tempting to use benzos or other downers to help move out of overamping. Taking benzos, especially in combination with heroin or alcohol can raise the risk for more serious complications like respiratory depression. A safer choice would be to drink some herbal tea, like chamomile, which is available at most grocery stores.

How do I take care of myself after overamping?

After an intense or uncomfortable time you may find yourself feeling exhausted, confused, or even sad. Give yourself some time to rest after the drugs have worn off and check in with yourself about how you feel. You might find it very difficult to sleep, despite being tired. Eating a good meal, laying down for a nap, and taking a hot shower might help you feel more like yourself.



You might consider taking some supplements like L-theanine and magnesium, which have been shown to reduce anxiety and muscle tension. Herbal tinctures or teas might also help you get to sleep. Look into herbs like skullcap, valerian, kava, chamomile, and passionflower.

If you are taking other medications, check in with your doctor or other medical provider to see if any herbal tinctures or supplements you might take are safe. Many herbs have interactions with both prescription and over the counter pharmaceuticals.

When can overamping be an emergency?

It is important to remember that unless there is a serious medical emergency, overamping will pass. In a non-emergency situation, support and rest will be the best options for helping you or your friend through an overamp.

We know that EMTs, healthcare providers, and police can be very stigmatizing towards people who use drugs. It makes sense that you may feel unsure about calling but certain situations do need special medical care. If you must leave, wait until the paramedics arrive to at least make sure help gets to your friend.

When you call 911, state the actual negative effect — i.e., "my friend is having multiple seizures and they need help." Don't use the words overamping or overdosing, and don't tell them that drugs have been taken over the phone — wait until the paramedics arrive. Waiting to disclose drug use helps reduce the risk that police will be dispatched to the scene.

Your state may have a Good Samaritan Law that protects the person who called for help from being arrested or prosecuted. These laws differ from state to state — some only protect you against certain charges, and other states don't have these policies at all. You can look up your state at

nextdistro.org/policies

Medical emergencies associated with overamping include:

Stroke

Strokes are caused by blood vessels in the brain being blocked or breaking. They can be deadly. If you think someone is having a stroke, call 911 right away. Signs include:

- Trouble communicating, like extremely slurred words or loss of speech
- Droopy and numb face
- Sudden numbness on one side of the body
- A painful headache that seems to come out of nowhere
- Not being able to see out of one eye

Heart Attack

A heart attack caused by overamping will look the same as a heart attack that doesn't involve drugs. If you think someone is having a heart attack, call 911 or get them medical attention immediately. If they lose consciousness and you know CPR, you can perform CPR or rescue breathing on them until first responders arrive. Signs include:

- Difficulty breathing
- Breaking out in a cold sweat
- Squeezing, pressure, or crushing pain in the chest, which may last for several minutes or might come and go
- Lightheadedness/dizziness
- Pain, pressure, & tightness in the neck, shoulders, jaw, or back

Overheating

If someone is sweating a lot, has chills, or feels hot to the touch, it's likely that they have a fever. Drinking water or Gatorade, opening a window, and using cold compresses can help break a fever, but if it gets to over 104°F the body can over heat. It can be hard to tell how hot someone is without a thermometer. Some signs include:

- Headaches, body aches, chills, and dizziness that won't go away after attempts to cool down
- Hot, dry skin, as opposed to sweaty skin
- Passing out
- Pale, bluish, or gray skin
- Extreme confusion
- Rapid heart rate and breathing

Seizures

If a seizure happens, stay calm and make sure you move anything that can hurt the person out of their way. Keep an eye on them in case they start choking or vomiting. Do not yell at the person, try to restrain

them, or force anything into their mouth. Signs of seizures include:

- Muscle spasm and loss of control of limbs
- Foaming at the mouth
- Grunting Sounds
- Inability to control bladder or bowel movements
- Losing consciousness
- Stiffening body

Seizures are an emergency and you should call 911 if:

- The seizure lasts over five minutes
- More than one seizure happens in a row
- The person loses consciousness and doesn't regain it
- The person stops breathing and doesn't start again
- The person got hurt during the seizure
- Skin turns red, blue, or pale and doesn't go back to normal after the seizure
- It is the first time a person has had a seizure

If you choose not to call 911 after a seizure, stay with the person until they are fully awake. Make sure there is no vomit or saliva in their throat and place them in the recovery position.

Psychosis

Most of the time drug induced psychosis, or a loss of contact with reality, will not need medical care. Psychosis where someone is trying to hurt themselves or someone else is extremely rare. Though it can be scary to see someone you know experiencing delusions or hallucinations, it's okay to wait it out. It will usually subside after a few hours but it may take longer for some people.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger (like using a knife to hurt your/themselves), paramedics can help. Unfortunately, there is a higher chance that the police will show up if you call 911. Mental health crisis lines like 988 may be able to provide extra support without involving the police, but they could also decide that the situation is dangerous and choose to send them anyway.

When it comes to overamping, your setting and mindset will make all the difference. Often when individuals are overamping, it helps to reassure them that the bad trip is temporary and will end. People tend to calm down in dark quiet environments with a trusted person keeping them company. If the overamp becomes medically significant, seek immediate medical attention.